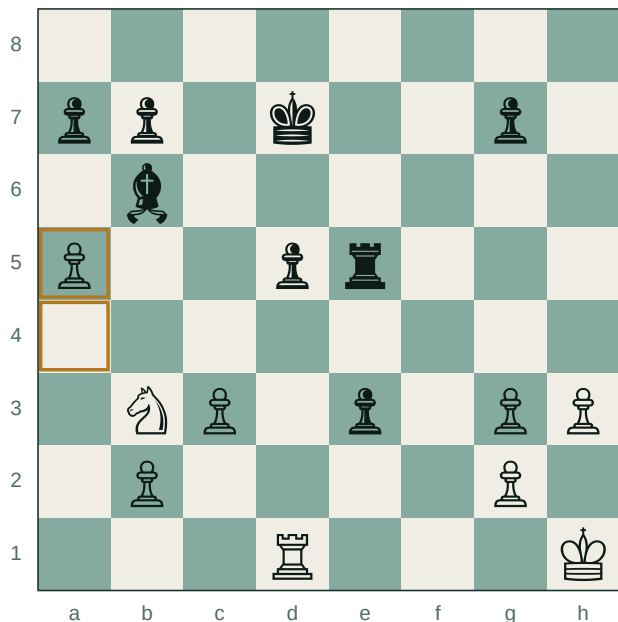


Clearance tactics: Black, move 26

Clearance tactics

Black to move



Previous move: 26.a5. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

26...e2 27. Re1 Bf2 28. Rxe2 Rxe2

26...e2 The pawn moves from e3 to e2. Recorded reply: **27.Re1**.

27...Bf2 The bishop moves from b6 to f2. Recorded reply: **28.Rxe2**.

28...Rxe2 The rook captures the rook on e2.

At the end, nominal material is White 9 / Black 12 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +4. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +4:** the balance goes from -1 to +3. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Opening a line helps only if your next move is timely. The defender may close the line or create a stronger threat.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A clearance move vacates a square or opens a line for another piece. The clearing piece may sacrifice itself to gain the time needed for the follow-up.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the rook, bishop, queen, or knight that needs access, then locate the friendly piece blocking its route or destination.

The defending king is on h1. Geometrically undefended: knight on b3 and rook on d1. Check for tactical protection.